

DECODED EXPLAINED

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AI's Next Test — Reaching India's Informal Women Worker

AI's next test — reaching India's informal women worker

India's journey towards Viksit Bharat by 2047 rests on whether the productivity gains unlocked by artificial intelligence (AI) are broadly shared or concentrated among those already well-served. AI is reshaping value chains across agriculture, logistics, health care and financial services. The design choices in these systems, who they are built for, whose data they train on, and whose languages they speak, will determine whether this transformation amplifies India's inclusive growth story or adds a dimension to structural inequalities.

About 82% of working women in India are in informal employment according to a 2018 ILO report, spanning agriculture, home-based production, domestic services and micro-enterprises. The gender implications of AI adoption are, above all, a question of economic inclusion. India's AI Governance Guidelines, released in November 2025, set out seven guiding principles, including fairness and equity; translating these into gender-responsive outcomes is both a governance priority and a development opportunity. As UN Women has warned, AI is already reimagining reality for billions, but it is still getting women wrong; without gender-responsive design, testing and oversight, it risks amplifying stereotypes, discrimination and digital violence instead of expanding opportunity.

In agriculture and informal work

AI holds considerable promise for Indian farmers through precision agriculture applications, real-time advisory on crop health, input optimisation and market access. With 76.9% of rural women engaged in agriculture as in *Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2023-24* reporting, women are a primary constituency. Early evidence is telling: a 2024 study of Farmer.Chat, deployed across 12 States, found that 61% of women users reported improved quality of life within 45 days, with engagement levels two to three times those of male users. While the specific design features driving this outcome



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Artificial Intelligence (AI) must empower informal women workers for truly inclusive economic growth

require further documentation, the results suggest that when AI agricultural tools reach women, keeping in mind language, land access patterns, mobility constraints, and relevance, meaningful engagement follows. Building on this foundation, three areas merit focused attention as India scales its AI deployment.

Governance priorities

First, gender impact assessments. The India AI Governance Guidelines' principles of fairness and equity require operationalisation through proportionate gender impact assessments for AI systems affecting economic opportunity, welfare access or safety for women and girls. These should examine whether outcomes vary by sex, location, caste, disability and work status, and whether redressal mechanisms are accessible in regional languages. Where AI decisions on credit, employment or welfare cannot be explained, trust suffers disproportionately among marginalised groups. Similarly, Gender Responsive Budgeting offers a practical test for decisions on AI spend. For any significant AI investment, four questions can be applied: which women will benefit; which specific barrier (access, language, safety or capability) is being addressed; how outcomes will be measured; and which budget line will finance corrective action if results fall short.

Second, AI literacy as public infrastructure. Access to tools is a necessary but not sufficient condition for inclusion. Training programmes for women in informal work must be designed around their time constraints, literacy levels and livelihood contexts. Embedding AI literacy within *Deen Dayal Antyodaya Yojana - National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM)*, *Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushalya Yojana (DDU-GKY)* and Skill India, with linkages to Mission Shakti's Sakhi network, would allow trusted community infrastructure to carry new digital capability. The measure of success should be outcome-based: did this help a woman access an entitlement, navigate a platform, or move to

better-paid work? Third, digital safety as a condition for economic participation. Technology-facilitated gender-based violence, including deepfakes, online harassment and non-consensual imagery, creates a measurable "chilling effect", discouraging women from participating fully in digital economic spaces. The IT (Amendment) Rules, 2021 require grievance mechanisms for harmful content; the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY)'s proposed mandatory labelling of AI-generated synthetic content adds further protection. Effective implementation, with accessible survivor-facing remedies in regional languages, is a prerequisite for women's sustained digital participation.

The National Commission for Women's review of cyber laws provides evidence-based recommendations warranting timely inter-ministerial action.

AI prosperity for all

India has built substantial AI infrastructure in a short period: the IndiaAI Mission, the BHASHa Interface for India (BHASHINI) multilingual platform, the AI Governance Guidelines and targeted cross-sector partnerships. The India AI Impact Summit 2026 showed that these ambitions are matched by a growing ecosystem of practitioners, innovators and civil society.

The opportunity is to ensure that the productivity gains from this infrastructure reach those at the base of the economic pyramid, viz., women farmers, home-based workers, self-help group members, platform participants. This requires deliberate design: in procurement standards, training programmes, safety frameworks and the measurement of success.

By 2047, the measure of India's AI success should not be aggregate indicators alone, but whether women in informal work have gained meaningful, productive access to the tools and opportunities that AI enables. That is the standard consistent with Viksit Bharat, and it is within India's reach.

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India's AI Governance Guidelines (Key Sutras of AI Governance)

- **Trust is the Foundation**
 - Trust that individuals will use these tools responsibly
 - Trust is the foundational principle that guides all AI development and deployment in India.
- **People First**
 - AI systems must be developed and deployed in ways that strengthen human agency and reflect societal values.
 - From a governance standpoint, this requires that humans retain meaningful control over AI systems wherever possible, supported by effective human oversight.
- **Innovation over restraint**
 - All other things being equal, responsible innovation should be prioritised over cautionary restraint.
- **Fairness and Equity**
 - AI systems should therefore be designed and evaluated to ensure fairness and to avoid bias or discrimination, particularly against marginalised communities.
- **Accountability**
 - To ensure that India's AI ecosystem progresses based on trust, AI developers and deployers should remain visible and accountable.
- **Understandable by Design**
 - Though AI systems are probabilistic, they must have clear explanations and disclosures to help users and regulators understand how the system works, what it means for the user,
- **Safety, Resilience and Sustainability**
 - AI systems should be designed with safeguards to minimise risks of harm and should be robust and resilient.

AI's Next Test — Reaching India's Informal Women Worker

● The Core Stakes

- India's journey towards Viksit Bharat by 2047 rests on whether productivity gains unlocked by AI are broadly shared or concentrated among those already well-served
- About 82% of working women in India are in informal employment according to a 2018 ILO report, spanning agriculture, home-based production, domestic services, and micro-enterprises; the gender implications of AI adoption are, above all, a question of economic inclusion
- India's AI Governance Guidelines, released in November 2025, set out seven guiding principles including fairness and equity;

● Promise in Agriculture and Informal Work

- AI holds considerable promise for Indian farmers through precision agriculture, real-time crop-health advisory, input optimisation, and market access; with 76.9% of rural women engaged in agriculture as per PLFS 2023-24, women are a primary constituency

● Three Governance Priorities

- First, gender impact assessments for AI systems affecting economic opportunity, welfare access, or safety, examining whether outcomes vary by sex, location, caste, disability, and work status
- Second, AI literacy as public infrastructure, designed around women's time constraints and livelihood contexts, embedded within DAY-NRLM, DDU-GKY, and Skill India, with linkages to Mission Shakti's Sakhi network
- Third, digital safety as a condition for economic participation, since technology-facilitated gender-based violence, including deepfakes and online harassment, creates a measurable “chilling effect” discouraging women from digital economic spaces

AI's Next Test — Reaching India's Informal Women Worker

AI Prosperity for All

○ India has built substantial AI infrastructure in a short period, the **IndiaAI Mission, the BHASHINI multilingual platform, the AI Governance Guidelines, and the India AI Impact Summit 2026**

Digital India BHASHINI is India's Artificial Intelligence (AI) led language translation platform.

How a Political Term Can Majorly Fix Urban India's Water Woes

How a political term can majorly fix urban India's water woes

Over the past few decades, Indian cities have depended more and more on distant rivers and groundwater; this has rendered higher energy bills, political disputes, greater vulnerability to drought and contamination; a focused agenda for one political cycle can stabilise urban water services

Manish Dubey
K.V. Santhosh Ragavan

How much can realistically change within the span of a single political term? The answer matters because India's wider growth and development ambitions now hinge on how its cities handle water.

Urban India is expected to drive the bulk of GDP growth this decade – yet many city water systems remain fragile. Utilities lose more than 30% of the water they produce before it reaches consumers or is billed, a measure known as non-revenue water.

Only around 27% of sewage is treated, leaving significant potential for reuse untapped.

Many utilities also recover less than 55% of their operation and maintenance costs through user charges, limiting their ability to maintain networks and improve services.

In effect, India is trying to build a 'Viksit Bharat' on top of a leaky and crumbling urban water system.

Fortunately, a focused agenda for one political cycle can stabilise urban water services, especially for those who are currently worst served. Such an agenda comes to light by answering four questions: Where does the water come from? How efficiently is it moved and used? Who receives what? And how is it paid for?

Where does the water come from? Over the last few decades, Indian cities have steadily depended more and more on distant rivers and groundwater. This has rendered higher energy bills, political disputes over allocations, and greater vulnerability to drought and contamination. Within one political term, cities are unlikely to abandon these sources altogether but they can reduce their dependence.

This starts with a simple change in mindset: treating rainwater and treated wastewater as mainstream sources rather than as fringe add-ons. Most large cities receive enough rain on their roofs, roads and open spaces to make a meaningful contribution to local demand if it is captured.

Similarly, a significant volume of wastewater can be treated to a standard suitable for non-drinking uses, such as industrial cooling, construction, landscaping, and flushing.

Practically, this means three kinds of policies over the next few years: stricter enforcement and incentivising of rainwater harvesting in large buildings and layouts; a clear plan to route treated wastewater to high-demand users who do not need drinking-quality water; and realistic targets to meet part of the city's non-potable demand from these sources.

A city that meets even a quarter of these needs through rain and reuse will be less at the mercy of reservoirs and over-stressed aquifers.

How efficiently is water moved? Many urban water providers are public utilities or departments that face familiar political, regulatory, and capacity constraints. They often operate with high non-revenue water, limited wastewater



Utilities lose more than 30% of the water they produce before it reaches consumers or is billed, a measure known as non-revenue water. GETTY IMAGES

treatment and reuse, and weak revenue collection. These are important reasons why supply is intermittent, pressure is low, and expansion into poorer neighbourhoods is delayed so often.

Over a single term, then, three steps are achievable to good effect. First, clarify responsibility. A clear mandate and support from the State government and formal coordination mechanisms with shared standards and joint planning can significantly improve service delivery.

Second, get serious about measuring and managing losses. In most Indian cities, a large share of water is lost before it even reaches a tap, due to leaks or unbilled consumption. Over a four- or five-year horizon, utilities can map their networks into districts, metered areas, install bulk meters at key points, and run sustained leak reduction programmes in the worst performing districts.

Third, modernise basic customer-facing services. This includes universal metering for larger consumers, better billing and collection systems, and accessible grievance redress mechanisms.

When people know how much they use, what they pay for, and where they can raise complaints, losses decline, and demand about tariffs, service levels, and equity are easier to have. Better information also helps utilities manage operations and plan investments.

Who receives what?

Current approaches for coverage, delivery and affordability have not closed the equity gap. Free standposts and ad-hoc tankers are important safety nets but they often coexist with tariffs and subsidies that benefit those already connected to the network. The result is a pattern where poorer households may pay more per litre – through time, health and informal payments – than those receiving piped water at low, flat rates.

Most water providers operate with high non-revenue water, limited wastewater treatment and reuse, and weak revenue collection: these are important reasons why supply is intermittent, pressure is low, and expansion into poorer neighbourhoods is delayed

A one-term reform agenda can start to change this by making it smarter.

One strand is to rethink service benchmarks. National per-capita norms have their place but cities can use local data to prioritise a guaranteed minimum amount of safe water for every resident – regardless of neighbourhood or tenure. This may mean investing in last-mile connections, shared infrastructure, and better pressure management in low-income and informal areas, rather than only in network extensions to new real estate.

Another strand is to redesign tariffs and subsidies so that they protect basic needs while discouraging waste. This is often framed as a technical exercise but at heart it is a political choice: should scarce public support be spread thinly across all users or focused more on those who need it most?

Over a term, cities can pilot and refine tariff structures that combine lifeline blocks, cross-subsidies from higher consumption, and targeted support for the poor, backed by transparent communication about why these changes are being made.

Who pays for it?

A one-term agenda can also change how water investments are chosen and evaluated. Too often, decisions focus on

construction costs while neglecting long-term operation, maintenance, and the broader benefits of good water management, including lower health costs and less flood damage.

Before approving major projects, cities should ask three questions: (i) Have all reasonable options for reducing demand or losses before adding new supply? (ii) Have the full lifetime costs, including energy, maintenance, and adaptation to climate risks been considered? (iii) Have environmental and social impacts of choices such as protecting wetlands versus piping water from afar valued?

Answering these questions does not require new laws. It requires better guidance, capacity building, and a willingness to learn from successful examples. Over a term, States and cities can build these habits into appraisal processes, perhaps starting with a few 'lighthouse' projects that explicitly test and demonstrate better ways of planning and financing.

Towards a single system

None of these changes will be simple. There will be entrenched interests, capacity gaps, and the ever-present temptation to announce something big and visible rather than fix what already exists. Yet these reforms are not utopian. They fall squarely within what an aligned city-State combination can start and significantly advance within a single political cycle.

Overall, India must shift from counting connections to managing performance and resilience, treating water, energy, finance and institutions as a single system, and investing equally in operations and local capacity.

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How a Political Term Can Majorly Fix Urban India's Water Woes

India's Urban Water Utilities: A Leaky Foundation for Viksit Bharat

> 30%

of water produced is
lost before reaching
consumers (non-revenue water)

~27%

of sewage is
treated, leaving reuse
potential untapped

● Non-Revenue Water (NRW)

○ The volume of water produced but not billed to customers, lost through leaks, theft, or metering inaccuracies, a key inefficiency metric for water utilities globally

How a Political Term Can Majorly Fix Urban India's Water Woes

● Where Water Comes From

- Indian cities have steadily depended more on distant rivers and groundwater, rendering higher energy bills, political disputes over allocations, and greater vulnerability to drought and contamination
- Within a single term, cities can reduce this dependence by treating rainwater and treated wastewater as mainstream sources: stricter enforcement of rainwater harvesting in large buildings, routing treated wastewater to high-demand non-drinking users, and setting realistic targets for non-potable demand from these sources

● How Efficiently Water Is Moved

- Many urban water providers face high non-revenue water, limited wastewater treatment and reuse, and weak revenue collection, key reasons why supply is intermittent, pressure is low, and expansion into poorer neighbourhoods is delayed
- Over a single term, three steps are achievable: clarify responsibility through a clear mandate and coordination with the State government; measure and manage losses through district metered areas and sustained leak reduction; and modernise customer-facing services through universal metering, better billing, and accessible grievance redress

● Who Receives What, and Who Pays

- Current approaches to coverage, delivery, and affordability haven't closed the equity gap; poorer households often pay more per litre through time, health, and informal payments than those receiving piped water at low flat rates
- Cities can rethink service benchmarks to guarantee a minimum amount of safe water for every resident, and redesign tariffs and subsidies using lifeline blocks and cross-subsidies from higher consumption to protect basic needs while discouraging waste

India, Bangladesh Must Not Just Renew Ganga Treaty. They Should Reimagine It

India, Bangladesh must not just renew Ganga Treaty. They should reimagine it



SRINIVAS CHOKKAKULA

AS THE 30-year term of the 1996 Ganga Water Treaty between India and Bangladesh approaches its conclusion, discussions about its future are gathering momentum. Much of the public debate is about whether the treaty will be renewed or revised. But a more consequential question is, what kind of agreement will it be? The political, institutional and ecological conditions that produced the 1996 treaty are vastly different. The negotiations are likely to be about much more than water sharing at Farakka.

The 1996 treaty had a single-point agenda of water sharing, following India's decision to build the Farakka barrage. The treaty provided a flow-dependent water-sharing arrangement that includes a 50:50 pro-rata sharing when the flows at Farakka dip below a limit. Bangladesh has often expressed its dissatisfaction about not receiving its due share during the dry seasons.

The next Ganga Treaty is not likely to be restricted to this one specific transborder issue. It will transcend territories and borders, within and outside, enlarging the scope of negotiations. The negotiations will be challenging, especially given the new political realities in Bangladesh. But they can also offer new opportunities for robust water diplomacy and enduring relations between India and Bangladesh.

There are two reasons why the negotiations will have an expanded agenda.

First, politics have become more complex. The 1996 treaty, signed after decades of deliberations, reflected a particular political moment of relatively stable bilateral relations. The treaty emerged from sustained Track 1 and Track 2 engagements that built trust and goodwill. Today, the negotiations are likely to be shaped as much by domestic political dynamics as by bilateral diplomatic considerations. Dhaka will find it challenging to navigate the antagonistic sentiment

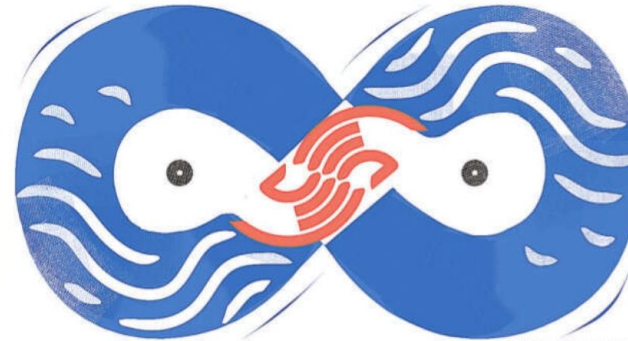


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

towards India at home. In India, too, the federal politics surrounding Ganga water-sharing are no less complex. West Bengal's resistance prioritising its own needs and Bihar's allegations of siltation upstream of Farakka leading to floods will both pose challenges.

Second, the agenda has expanded beyond Farakka. Besides the Teesta, the recent protracted source of tension, disagreements over multiple shared rivers in the past three decades will impact the negotiations. Further, the concerns are unlikely to be just about water-resources sharing and development. The scope will expand to growing water-related risks, with greater uncertainty due to climate change. Climate change pushes the agenda beyond bilateral water allocations to regional-level responses to managing Himalayan glaciers, hydrological extremes, ecosystem resilience and shared vulnerabilities.

These changes have a few critical practical implications for the negotiations.

First, there is a need to avoid what political geographers call the "territorial trap"—the assumption that negotiations occur between the two sovereigns, represented by Delhi and Dhaka. Water diplomacy cannot be separated from internal diplomacy efforts, both in India

The 1996 treaty, signed after decades of deliberations, reflected a particular political moment of relatively stable bilateral relations. The treaty emerged from sustained Track 1 and Track 2 engagements that built trust and goodwill

and Bangladesh. Dhaka must figure out a way to navigate the polarised politics within. Further, posturing has its limits as a bargaining strategy. Signalling closer engagement with China in the Teesta basin may strengthen Bangladesh's negotiating position in the short term, but it also risks securitising negotiations and narrowing opportunities to explore mutual benefits. As the downstream riparian, Dhaka's long-term interests are better served through stable cooperation than through strategic posturing.

India, too, will need to invest in some amount of federal diplomacy despite the conducive equations after the recent elections in Bihar and West Bengal. Getting the states on board will not be easy. Water is an emotive subject and can offer opportunities for the parties in opposition to mobilise resistance from within.

Second, shared rivers create indispensable interdependencies—a less acknowledged but essential characteristic of transboundary rivers. It is not a zero-sum game when water-sharing considerations accompany those of coping with collective risks. The negotiations must build on this for an enduring bilateral relationship. The interdependencies may not always be bilateral. They may transcend to

become regional in character. Framing it as interdependencies shifts the focus to shared gains. Better management of floods, fisheries, inland navigation for trade, improved flood forecasting, and joint ecological restoration efforts could create benefits that extend beyond questions of water allocation.

Third, an enabling response to the first two is to invest in institutional avenues. Both India and Bangladesh will need to invest in appropriate institutional processes to channel polarised domestic politics in support of negotiations. Bilateral institutions need revisiting as well. Earlier institutional choices of the overarching Joint Rivers Commission and the Joint Committee for implementing the Ganga Treaty will not be adequate. They were conceived to implement agreements, not to manage uncertainties. The changed realities and greater uncertainties, including water availability, will need robust and resilient transborder institutions to address the enhanced scope of issues—water sharing, data collection and monitoring, dispute resolution, responding to risks, etc.

Finally, both countries will have to reinvent the political capital that made the 1996 treaty possible, and reinvest in it. The treaty negotiations can be a means to do it. Alongside Track 1 diplomacy, both countries should encourage Track 2 dialogues to generate ideas, sustain dialogue and build intellectual and political constituencies to support the dialogue. The 1996 treaty benefitted from such engagement. The Centre for Policy Research was among those at the forefront of such initiatives and contributed to developing a working draft of the treaty.

The negotiations can offer an opportunity to revisit the regional vision that India and Bangladesh jointly championed when SAARC was conceived. The institutional form may have to evolve beyond SAARC, but the underlying strategic rationale has become stronger. The next Ganga Treaty, therefore, presents an opportunity not merely to renew a bilateral water-sharing arrangement but to reimagine a regional strategic vision to address challenges of this new age of shared vulnerabilities and fragmented global economy.

The writer is president and chief executive, Centre for Policy Research, New Delhi. Views are personal

India, Bangladesh Must Not Just Renew Ganga Treaty. They Should Reimagine It



- It is one of the two most important headstreams of the Ganga which meets the Alaknanda at Devprayag to form the Ganga
- Flowing for nearly 2,525 km, the Ganga passes through the states of Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, and West Bengal.
- It forms one of the world's most densely populated basins, accounting for 26.4% of India's geographical area and supporting nearly 50% of India's population.
- Final Drainage: Bay of Bengal.
- Enters plains at Haridwar.
- Joined by major tributaries: Ramganga, Yamuna, Gomti, Ghaghara, Gandak, Kosi. Plains provide extremely fertile alluvial soil. River meanders widely due to low gradient.
- The river slows down and splits into distributaries forming the world's largest delta.

India, Bangladesh Must Not Just Renew Ganga Treaty. They Should Reimagine It



Left bank Tributaries

- **Ramganga River :**
 - Originates in the southern slopes of Dudhatoli Hill in the Chamoli district of Uttarakhand.
 - It also flows through the dun valley of Corbett National Park.
 - It finally meets the Ganga near Kannauj.
- **Gomti River**
 - It extends 900km through UP and meets the Ganges River in Ghazipur
- **Ghagra**
 - Alternatively known as Karnali or Kauriala, it is a trans-boundary perennial river originating from the Tibetan plateau near Lake Mansarovar.
 - It is a major left-bank tributary of the Ganga and joins it at Chhapra in Bihar.
 - Sarayu River : left-bank tributary of River Ghaghara and passes through Ayodhya

India, Bangladesh Must Not Just Renew Ganga Treaty. They Should Reimagine It



- It is formed by the union of the Kali and Trisuli rivers, which rise in the Great Himalayan Range in Nepal
- It enters the Ganga river opposite Patna in a place called Sonapur after a winding course of 765 km
- KOSI
 - Its unstable nature has been attributed to the heavy silt it carries during the monsoon season, Due to this, it is also termed as “The Sorrow of Bihar”.

India, Bangladesh Must Not Just Renew Ganga Treaty. They Should Reimagine It



Right Bank Tributaries

- **Yamuna River**
 - Largest and the most important tributary. It unites with the Ganga near Triveni Sangam, Allahabad.
- **Son River**
 - The Son River rises in the Amarkantak Plateau.
 - Its source is close to the origin of the Narmada. Joins Ganga in Bihar
- The Damodar river rises in the hills of the Chotanagpur plateau and flows through a rift valley. It joins the Hugli River 48 km below Kolkata.

To Fix Unemployment, Fix the Economy First

The Ganga Water Sharing Treaty, 1996 is an agreement between India and Bangladesh on sharing the waters of the Ganga at Farakka during the dry season. It was signed on 12 December 1996 and was designed to remain in force for 30 years, which means it is set to expire in December 2026.

To manage the sharing of Ganges waters at the Farakka Barrage, which diverts water to India's Hooghly River to maintain Calcutta Port's navigability.

Farakka Barrage – It was built in 1975 across the Ganges at Farakka, West Bengal.

Water sharing to be by 10-day periods during the lean season (Jan 1 – May 31) every year

Sharing formula

If the flow at Farakka is less than 70,000 cusecs, sharing is 50:50.

If flow is between 70,000–75,000 cusecs, Bangladesh receives a fixed 35,000 cusecs & India gets the remainder.

If the flow is more than 75,000 cusecs, India gets 40,000 cusecs, while Bangladesh receives the balance.

India, Bangladesh Must Not Just Renew Ganga Treaty. They Should Reimagine It

Problems in the new negotiation

Agenda Has Expanded

- First, politics have become more complex; the 1996 treaty reflected a stable bilateral moment and emerged from sustained Track 1 and Track 2 engagement, while today's negotiations will be shaped as much by domestic political dynamics in both countries
- Second, the agenda has expanded beyond Farakka; disagreements over multiple shared rivers, growing climate-driven water risks around Himalayan glaciers and hydrological extremes, and the recognition that shared rivers create indispensable interdependencies rather than a zero-sum game

Key Practical Implications

- There is a need to avoid the “territorial trap,” the assumption that negotiations occur only between the two sovereigns; framing shared rivers as interdependencies shifts focus to shared gains like flood management, fisheries, and inland navigation
- Both countries need to invest in institutional avenues; the existing Joint Rivers Commission and Joint Committee were conceived to implement agreements, not manage uncertainties, and will need strengthening for the enhanced scope of issues
- Both countries will have to reinvent the political capital that made the 1996 treaty possible, through both Track 1 diplomacy and Track 2 dialogues to build intellectual and political constituencies for the negotiation

India, Bangladesh Must Not Just Renew Ganga Treaty. They Should Reimagine It

Tracks of Diplomacy

Track 1 Diplomacy: Official, government-to-government diplomacy conducted by diplomats, heads of state, and other formal authorities.

Track 1.5 Diplomacy: Semi-formal dialogue where government officials and non-governmental experts engage together, less formal than Track 1.

Track 2 Diplomacy: Purely unofficial dialogue between non-governmental experts, with no direct government involvement.

To Fix Unemployment, Fix the Economy First

Consider the following tributaries of river Ganga:

1. Gandak
2. Kosi
3. Ghaghara
4. Gomti

Which of the following is the correct order of the above rivers from east to west?

This question was previously asked in
CDS GK Previous Paper 5 (Held
On: 4 Feb 2018)

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1. 3-4-1-2
2. 2-1-3-4
3. 2-3-1-4
4. 1-2-4-3

With reference to the Himalayan rivers joining the Ganga downstream of Prayagraj from West to East, which one of the following sequences is correct?

This question was previously asked in
UPSC CSE Prelims 2024: General
Studies Official Paper

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1. Ghaghara - Gomati - Gandak - Kosi
2. Gomati - Ghaghara - Gandak - Kosi
3. Ghaghara - Gomati - Kosi - Gandak
4. Gomati - Ghaghara - Kosi - Gandak

To Fix Unemployment, Fix the Economy First

Consider the following pairs:

National Park **River flowing through the Park**

1. Corbett National Park: Ganga

2. Kaziranga National Park : Manas

3. Silent Valley National Park: Kaveri

Which of the above pairs is/are correctly matched?

This question was previously asked in

UPSC Civil Services (Prelims)
Official Paper 2013

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1. 1 and 2

2. 3 only

3. 1 and 3

4. None

To Fix Unemployment, Fix the Economy First

To fix unemployment, fix the economy first

The Cockroach Janta Party's movement has highlighted the political urgency for reforming the economy to create more employment for India's youth. Fixing the education system alone will not solve the unemployment problem. The basic structure of the economy must be reformed.

China and India, the only two countries in the world with populations exceeding one billion, have the greatest need for meaningful employment. If citizens are not fully employed, and incomes of masses do not rise, their economies cannot grow. China has done much better than India in this regard; the per capita income of Chinese citizens has risen roughly eight times faster than Indians' in the last 30 years.

India's leaders find themselves in the middle of conflicting trends. First, they are pushing ahead with reforms for 'ease of doing business'; diluting the rights of workers to organise; and weakening environmental protection. Second, they are promoting the wide-spread application of Artificial Intelligence (AI) to improve 'productivity' (and other benefits) in agriculture, industry, health and education, with productivity defined, purely in economic terms, as more output with less human input. Third, they also see the need to change the pattern of growth and increase employment elasticity. Employment elasticity is the amount of meaningful employment created with each unit of GDP growth, in which India has been a laggard since the liberal market economic reforms of the 1990s.

Since India has the largest population of youth in the world, its economic growth should have the highest employment elasticity. However, the increased adoption of AI will only make it worse.

The China model
China has invested billions to become an AI superpower and has raced to integrate the technology



Arun Maira
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Economy: The Road
to a More Equitable
Society'

across a range of industries. By 2024, more than two million robots were already working in Chinese factories. And in Beijing, Shanghai and Shenzhen, Meituan, the nation's largest food delivery service, has experimented with using small autonomous robots to deliver food. But China's advances in AI have run headlong into a growing problem: anxiety over the workers who could be displaced.

China's political and economic history reveals that, despite being an authoritarian country, the Chinese government is very attentive to what people are thinking and saying on the Internet. History has taught them that another revolution will form if disenchanted and educated youth rise along with the disgruntled workers and peasants. They know they must respond.

Unemployment has been increasing in China. The unemployment rate for migrant workers rose to 5.7% in March this year, which has been the highest in nearly three years for China, while youth unemployment stood at 16.3% in April. Moreover, 70% of unemployed young people are university graduates, with older laid-off workers facing prolonged periods of joblessness.

However, Chinese courts have been swift to act. A court ruled in May that a tech company had illegally laid-off a worker after replacing him with AI software. Another ruled that, "the development of artificial intelligence technology should be applied to liberating labour, promoting employment and improving people's livelihood". And yet another ruled that "companies that benefit from technology must, at the same time, adopt social responsibilities and protect worker rights".

China's Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security announced in January that it would roll out policies to address the impact of AI on jobs, including targeted support for key industries. In June, the State Council issued a plan on

implementing an "employment-first" strategy for the 2026-2030 period. Party officials have proposed sweeping government interventions such as requiring employers to offer training to help workers adapt to an AI-centric job market.

The Chinese government's 'people-first' ideology has served China's economy and its people well. China's leaders have remained socialists; they have always put the needs of common citizens, and the stability of China's society, above economists' demands for deregulation of markets and prices, especially with respect to labour, food, education, health, and housing.

The road ahead for India
Indian income levels must rise rapidly – in agriculture, manufacturing, and services. The government has added 'ease of living' to 'ease of doing business' as the purpose of the reforms required for India to become 'Viksit Bharat' by 2047. To make it a reality, it will have to put more teeth into its policies to increase employment and incomes, and stave off the negative impacts that AI will have on employment. Policies must require that employers take more responsibility for training their own workers; they must be restrained from laying them off.

New policies must put workers' rights ahead of capitalists' rights, as China has done. India's labour market reforms, with the four labour codes, are directed to improve 'ease of doing business', which is undoubtedly necessary. However, the 'ease of doing business' must now become subordinate to the ease of living and earning for all citizens.

India's leaders would do well to learn from China's leaders on how to navigate this moment in history. The rights of all workers must be firmly protected. While the views of financial investors must be heard, the views of workers and small-time entrepreneurs must be heard much more.

The 'ease of doing business' must now become subordinate to the ease of living and earning for all citizens

To Fix Unemployment, Fix the Economy First

- **Employment Elasticity of Growth**

- A measure of how much employment growth accompanies a given rate of GDP growth; low employment elasticity means economic growth is not translating into proportionate job creation, a persistent concern in India since the 1991 liberalisation reforms

Thank You